

Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD

Understanding and solving intractable resource governance problems.

[ABOUT ME](#) [BLOG](#) [CONSULTING](#) [CONTACT](#) [MY RESEARCH](#) [PUBLICATIONS](#) [RESOURCES](#) [TALKS](#) [TEACHING](#) [WORKSHOPS](#)

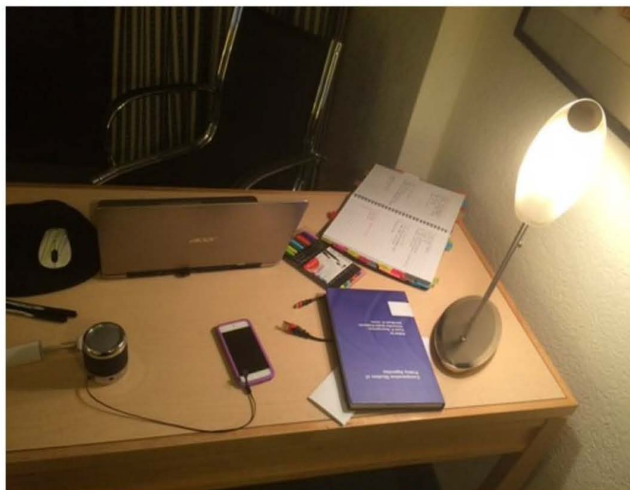
[Log in](#)

Warning Search

1
SHARES

How to undertake a literature review

I have been asked a few times for a blog post on how to conduct a proper literature review. This is hard to do sometimes because a lot of people have different methods to do their reviews of the literature (see examples [here](#), [here](#), [here](#) and [here](#)). I tweeted a few of the steps I undertake, but I figured the easiest way to do this was to actually write a full blog post with the protocol I follow. I usually teach my students (graduate and undergraduate) and my research assistants how to do each one of the steps, so I will be walking you through my own process, rather than any generally accepted version of a method for reviewing the literature. You can apply much of the research process (citation tracing, concept saturation, finding anchor authors and creating subheadings that are based on questions to be answered) to the process of **creating an annotated bibliography**.

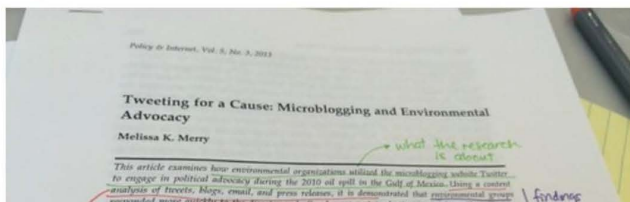


Right now I am doing a review of the literature on *online activism for environmental protection purposes*. This isn't a topic that is entirely new to me, because I do know some of the work and a few of the authors who have studied this particular issue, or at least online activism. Among these I can count **Dr. Melissa K. Merry** (University of Louisville), **Dr. Dave Karpf** (George Washington University), **Dr. Deen Freelon** (American University) and **Dr. Meredith Clark** (University of North Texas). Melissa's work is specifically on how environmental advocacy organizations have used Twitter, so citations to her work, and the papers she cites are **the backbone of the literature review**. Deen, Dave and Meredith have researched online activism, so their publications should be part of the **contextual components**.

An element of undertaking a literature review that almost nobody tells you about is the serendipitous nature of finding a specific author. For example, while I have tweeted quite a lot, and I knew of the work of Dave Karpf on online activism because I followed him on Twitter, I didn't know about the work of Melissa until she became my discussant at this year's Midwest Political Science Association conference and I Googled her work, which is COMPLETELY relevant to what I am studying right now. I knew of Deen and Meredith's work and their study of #BlackLivesMatter because I had followed it on Twitter. But it took me a citation tracing process based on Dave's 2010 piece to find **Heather Hodges and Galen Stocking's article on Twitter activism against the Keystone XL Pipeline**, which is VERY much specific to what I am researching now. So much of what I come across is actually rather serendipitous. Heather and Galen's paper then became also part of the **list of the anchor authors**.

1. Identify the main topic and the anchor authors.

The first stage of undertaking a literature review is **identifying the main topic for the review, and a few key authors**, what I called in the previous paragraph, *the anchor authors*. For example, for this review I'm doing on online environmental activism I identified three articles by Melissa, one by Dave, as my foundation ones.



SUBSCRIBE



About Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD

I am a Full Professor with the Methods Lab at the Facultad Latinoamericana de Ciencias Sociales (FLACSO) Sede Mexico. My research is interdisciplinary by nature, and I identify both as a political scientist and as a human geographer, the two fields in which I trained during my doctorate. For a long time, my work centered [...]

[more →](#)

Find Me Online

My Research Output

- > [Google Scholar Profile](#)
- > [E-mail](#)
- > [Academia.Edu](#)
- > [ResearchGate](#)
- > [Mendeley](#)
- > [ORCID](#)

My Social Networks

- > [Twitter / X](#)
- > [Facebook](#)
- > [LinkedIn](#)
- > [BlueSky](#)

Recent Posts

- > [How to map out debates in the scholarly literature](#)
- > [Making our research dialogue with the broader scholarly literature in our academic writing](#)
- > [A guiding framework to help learners write more analytically by focusing on the Description, Analysis and Interpretation stages of the research process \(GReDAI\)](#)
- > [Gap-spotting, problematization, finding a niche: How can researchers develop their contribution to the literature?](#)
- > [Doing a project per career stage versus executing multiple projects: Pros, cons and my own experience](#)

Recent Comments

- > [Gamegeek on Should public administration scholarship be subjected to the same transparency standards as political science? A response to Lars Tummers](#)
- > [ministitch1 on Reading, scribbling, highlighting, taking notes and organizing information from a journal article or book chapter – walking through my digital and analog processes](#)
- > [slot depo 5k on My Top 10 academic productivity tips, or how I submitted 5 pieces in 3 weeks](#)
- > [udinslot\[jago168\]djarur on Reshaping incentives: Encouraging tap water instead of bottled water](#)
- > [udinslot\[jago168\]djarur on How to make your claim of novelty and contributions to the scholarly literature VERY clear with an example](#)

Archives

Select Month ▼

I usually break down the literature review, if it is a research product in and of itself (like the one we generated for the UC MEXUS CONACYT project) in headings and summarize how each

literature, within each heading. So for example, if I were doing this literature review as a product itself, I probably would use a list of topics and headings like this:

1. Introduction.
2. The role of activism in policy change.
3. Activist strategies' repertoire: online and offline.
4. Experiences of online activists' in influencing domestic policy change.
5. Environmental activists' repertoires: online and offline.
6. How do environmental activists use online strategies to influence policy change.
7. Gaps in the literature.
8. Conclusions.

Some authors, like Dr. Eduardo Araral, publish their literature reviews as scholarly pieces in international journals. This **coauthored piece on Water Governance 2.0** is a really solid literature review with a critical component that provides additional insight than just summarizing the works published so far on the topic.

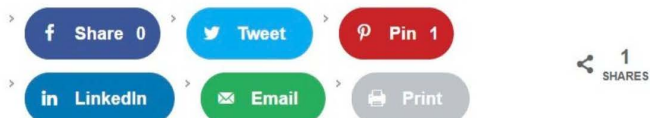
This **paper by Benson et al** is another good literature review published as a journal article (on water governance and integrated water resources management).

These pieces (by **Miranda et al 2011** and **by Batchelor**) on water governance are not published as journal articles, but remain solid literature reviews.

This **literature review by the Pacific Institute** on voluntary standards in environmental regulation is also quite solid.

Overall, the exercise of undertaking a literature review is an important and necessary one for students both at the undergraduate and at the graduate level, and that's why it is fundamental that we teach our students how to do them properly. Hopefully my post will answer some questions on how to conduct literature reviews!

You can share this blog post on the following social networks by clicking on their icon.



Posted in **academia**.

Tagged with **AcWri**, **literature review**.

By **Raul Pacheco-Vega** – April 28, 2017

rev="post-3821" 2 comments



2 Responses

Stay in touch with the conversation, subscribe to the **R.S.S. feed for comments on this post**.



Mohammad Shahnawaz Khan says

How to write a more comprehensive literature review ?

May 2, 2021 10:10 am

Continuing the Discussion

Writing a literature review assignment (and for instructors: providing guidance) – Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD *linked to this post on August 10, 2019*
[...] a literature review, based on [...]

Leave a Reply

Some HTML is OK

Name (required)

Email (required, but never shared)

Web

Post comment

or, reply to this post via **trackback**.

Proudly powered by WordPress and Carrington.

CARRINGTON FRAMEWORK BY Crowd Favorite™



Warning: Undefined array key "total_count_position" in /home/public/wp-content/plugins/social-pug/inc/functions-frontend.php on line 46